



Delete voice history

A security bug in Alexa allows hackers to access your voice history, which is why you should wipe it. <http://dgit.in/sep20-3>



Back to school

Google Assistant has added a bunch of features oriented at kids, including a ringing schoolbell. <http://dgit.in/sep20-4>

program to develop Amazon skill sets in 2018. According to C&EN, Rhodes disclosed that the skill set developed by HelixAI is a synthetic template that can be customised as per the intended use in specific laboratories. Questions such as “What is the molecular weight of...” exist in the aforementioned template with placeholders for names of chemicals, reagents, or other terms commonly used in labs.

Some other use cases include being able to hold a particular laboratories’ database or ‘knowledge base’, storing a lab’s operating procedure and experimental protocols, and allowing the assistant to walk researchers through commonly-performed, lab-specific procedures and protocol step-by-step. Helix also tracks a particular lab’s inventory allowing the lab owner to upload and access their inventory by merely using their voice. The skill can allow Alexa to pinpoint the exact location of specific items, check tools in and out, see who last used an item, and even note down order forms when supplies are running low, and automatically send them to a supplier.

Helix customises the template of their skill specific to a particular lab they have received an order from with the software development kit supplied by Amazon. Once the customised template is loaded up, the user can access it via an Amazon account and it can be utilised on any Alexa-enabled device including an Amazon smart speaker, Amazon’s Kindle Fire, or even a smartphone. The software has been extensively tested in DeLacy Rhodes’ lab and the pair even presented it at an American Chemical Society (ACS) meeting where it reportedly garnered positive feedback from chemists.

One of HelixAI’s very first customers was New England Biolabs (NEB), a supplier of reagents for molecular biology. They recruited Helix to develop a cloud-based, voice-activation system dubbed myNEB that it introduced to the public early in 2019. NEB worked with Helix on its restriction enzymes where not only the names of enzymes needed to be entered into the



Source: international.neb.com

myNEB, a customer of HelixAI, that is a cloud-based, voice service for laboratories

system but also a plethora of associated properties.

LABTWIN

Another similar offering is from LabTwin, a Berlin-based startup, founded by Magdalena Paluch and Steffen Gloth, that received financial backing from lab supply firm, Sartorius, and BCG Digital Ventures. The company began working on a lab voice assistant by leveraging NLP technology from a major tech company (undisclosed) in 2017. In 2019, LabTwin launched a mobile phone-based (Android and iOS) lab assistant. LabTwin views voice-activated documentation and note taking in labs as an unmet need and their answer is to provide an automated means of entering and accessing lab data. Much like Helix’s voice-activated lab assistant,

LabTwin’s basic product is also templatised so that it can be customised to a user’s needs. The training is done primarily via text programming and voice inputs to accommodate accents and pronunciations.

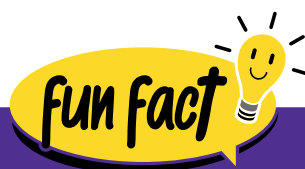
Users who enter lab data by voice into their mobile phone can later access all the information via a web page as well. LabTwin even has partnerships with some lab informatics and instrumentation firms that allow for automated data integration, which can save lots of time since it does away with manual logging. Some users, apart from the voice-activation function, also claim to use LabTwins as an ELN (electronic lab notebook) since you can



Magdalena Paluch, CEO and Co-Founder, LabTwin

Credit: labtwin.com

write reports with it, integrate images, and even voice notes. In addition, the system can dictate lab protocols, log completed steps in procedures, transcribe voice notes, set timers, reminders, and much more. LabTwins is also free for academics, which is a big plus point. In June 2019, the company also announced its new open API that can connect scientists with data sources, both inside and outside of the lab. They will enable scientists to instantly access external databases and data streams from sources such as informatic systems and lab equipment. The company also announced a Talk Back feature at the same time where LabTwin’s digital assistant leverages ML and voice-recognition techniques to speak back to scientists and guide them through protocols, provide recommendations, and even access scientific data. 



James Rhodes told C&EN about a funny incident the couple encountered when training their app. When James loaded in the recipe for lysogeny broth, which is commonly referred to as LB broth by microbiologists, Alexa insisted on calling it “pound broth” instead! A small tweak fixed the funny issue later on.